

Preservationists: Underdogs are suddenly the top dogs

Whoever chose Chicago as the logical place to hold a convention on historic preservation is probably, as his next venture, planning an ice cream factory in hell.

Still, that's where the National Trust for Historic Preservation held its mammoth annual gathering last week, and if the surrounding roar of demolitions was occasionally distracting, the convention, which took place in the stately, Edwardian precincts of the Drake hotel, was nearly always stimulating.

The National Trust is a private group, but it is federally funded and has been, for its 30 years of existence, the central body of the preservation movement. Only a few years ago the Trust's members seemed to be mainly pleasant women from Savannah who were interested in wallpaper — "the Bluehairs," as they're called by younger preservationists.

Not any more. To no one's amazement more than the Trust's, preservation has exploded into a national movement and the Trust has attracted a host of aggressive and thoughtful new members. Their interests go far beyond wallpaper and decorative moldings, beyond saving Southern mansions or picturesque colonial neighborhoods. Most of all, they no longer feel like either elitists or underdogs. The problem they talked about most in Chicago was what to do with their success, their power and their access to the public.

One who tried to sum up the prevailing attitude was Chester Liebs, head of the preservation program at the University of Vermont. "We have captured the public's attention," he told a symposium on future directions. "Now we have to transform this attention into a national ethic, a national system of environmental maintenance."

New preservationists like Liebs are concerned with the suburbs as much as the cities, with the rich ethnic flavor of a Chicago working class block as much as with the tailored cool of a Beacon Hill, with a 1940s shiny black storefront as much as with the colonial one next door. That means making choices, making value judgements: What's really worth saving?

ARCHITECTURE By ROBERT CAMPBELL

"We've been reactive underdogs," Liebs says, "with messianic dedication but no philosophy. We lived by buzzwords; old is better than new, cities are better than suburbs. We needed those to get attention when we were the underdogs. Now we have to transform ourselves mentally from the underdogs we were to the leaders we are."

Liebs and many others are afraid that unless someone starts thinking about values, preservation is in danger of becoming as destructive and mindless as its opposite, urban renewal, once was. An example of that was provided by another speaker, Louise Merritt, founder of Historic Albany. Merritt told a horror story of an Albany neighborhood, the Pastures, which like a Vietnamese village had to be destroyed in order to save it.

The culprit in Albany was the city. Determined to "revitalize" an old, architecturally distinguished neighborhood, the city began by acquiring every building in it and evicting every tenant. It then demolished all the "historically insignificant" buildings, about half the neighborhood, including all the worker's houses. The surviving buildings were mothballed — heat turned off, windows boarded up — while city planners sought a developer to do the place over into a "charming" historic district. They're still looking.

As Merritt rightly said, nothing was preserved that mattered: the neighborhood died the day the last person left it.

Roderick French of George Washington University talked about cities and suburbs. He argued that suburbs sort the population into separate enclaves — brickies in Malden, bankers in Weston — and this separation cripples society.

"Democracy," French pointed out, "requires significant shared experiences." He warned that preservation, with its back-to-the-city bias, may merely recapitulate the suburban problem, with different subcultures again sorting themselves into different pots, this time in town like the

young professionals on Boston's waterfront. "What a hollow victory if preservation restored everything about cities except their heterogeneity," French said.

Chester Liebs pointed to another side of the back-to-the-city ethic: "By the time a low-income person finally realizes the suburban dream of a single-family home, we may have made that dream seem second-rate."

The preservation movement has achieved one of the greatest, fastest victories of any environmental movement in American history. The victory has been the result of many factors: Energy crunches, a distrust of modern design, a general swing to conservatism, a natural turning away by one generation from the ideals, newness and mobility of its parents.

But much has also been due to the heroic efforts of the preservationists themselves. After such a triumph one could forgive smugness. What is exciting is that none exists. It's healthy and encouraging, and surprising to find the leaders of the movement today more inquiring and critical than ever, more committed than before to moving the nation toward a sane, fad-free ethic in which we will see ourselves as caretaking tenants of all our built worlds.